

PyData London 2026

The Human-in-the-Loop Is Tired

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Section 1

There is something to see here

we're all markdown engineers now

Based on a blog

The Human-in-the-Loop Is Tired

pydantic.dev/articles/the-human-in-the-loop-is-tired

the vibes are weird

"The dust hasn't settled on how we'll use this stuff at work - where we just optimise and automate, and where we rethink the whole job. But the rate of improvement is so high, and not slowing, that sitting on your hands isn't a defensible stance."

- Alan Nichol

[linkedin.com/posts/anichol_audience-slido-questions-ugcPost-7467886985756725248](https://www.linkedin.com/posts/anichol_audience-slido-questions-ugcPost-7467886985756725248)

Slop or not?

Hands up / hands down.

PLACEHOLDER - MEME SEQUENCE

One AI-slop artefact per slide, gross to subtle.

Each carries its own source link (Laura adds on selection).

Slop or not? (A)

```
import time
def retry(fn, attempts=3, base_delay=1.0):
    for attempt in range(attempts):
        try:
            return fn()
        except Exception:
            if attempt == attempts - 1:
                raise
            time.sleep(base_delay * 2 ** attempt)
```


Slop or not? (B)

```
def add_message(content, history=[]):  
    history.append({"role": "user", "content": content})  
    return history
```

Slop or not? (C)

```
def dedupe(items):  
    seen = set()  
    return [x for x in items if not (x in seen or seen.add(x))]
```

We're all evaluators now

Taste all the way down

"It's possible that Son of Anton decided the most efficient way to get rid of all the bugs was to get rid of all the software, which is technically and statistically correct."

- Silicon Valley, HBO

x.com/UiSavior/status/2062840449564332304

The connections that break

- communication ↔ meaning
- appearance of effort ↔ experience of it
- gloss of clarity ↔ actually understanding it

If Manidis pull-quote used: x.com/WillManidis/status/2057094527236665598

Section 2

Diagnosis

what it actually feels like

"Your company's new AI Agent Workflow"

The Rube Goldberg "AI Agent Workflow" clip.

orig. valentino.x (Instagram) - YouTube Shorts mirror youtube.com/shorts/rlkDBrSAI_s (Laura's copy watermarked "The Fountain Institute" - cite whichever version is screened)

It feels like a slot machine

Jeremy Howard clip - "illusion of control... you pull the lever... cherry cherry, bzzzz... Next time!"

x.com/teropa/status/2049406364011626498

"I simultaneously became snappier towards those who were asking me impromptu questions... and more rant-y towards those who were asking me how I was doing."

"fascinating, thrilling, and exhilarating, but it also left me feeling unmoored and drifting, questioning the permanence of what I was building."

- Eric Ma

ericmjl.github.io/blog/2026/5/2/how-i-recognized-and-handled-ai-burnout

literal Turing test machines

If meme used:

x.com/folaoftech/status/2062861496829309421

left behind? only me? will my skills matter?

If meme used: x.com/forrestbrazeal/status/1958553027834458285

"learning something that'll be out of date in 5 minutes"

- PyCon DE anxiety wall
- cost of learning when intelligence is cheap?
- does anything survive?

Laura's photo, PyCon DE 2026 (no external link) - meme candidate: x.com/KaiLentit/status/2021282230421651456

"friction is the thing that builds the understanding of the system in your head."

- Mario Zechner (Pi)

[youtube.com/watch?v=RjfbvDXpFIs](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RjfbvDXpFIs)

PLACEHOLDER - LATENCY

TTFT vs E2EL - TBD

Separate chat to finalise numbers + presentation.

Why it's not steerable

- slow
- noisy
- missing feedback

**you're not waiting on a tool -
you're waiting on someone who
isn't respecting your time**

The trade-offs are made for us, invisibly

The streaming metaphor - no dial, no readout.

"my context wasn't my context... zero observability."

- Mario Zechner (Pi)

youtube.com/watch?v=RjfbvDXpFIs

Section 3

Remedies & balms

what actually helps

**optimise for human experience,
not model output**

If you can't pop the hood, at least measure the exhaust

observability / tracing

If you're going to gamble, learn to count your cards

evals

Technical balms

- pre-mortems
- AGENTS.md from your review comments
- permission to just write the code

Make the output brain-friendly

respect your cognitive limit (~4-7 chunks)

Human balms

- pair against the grain
- name it ("oh - you too?")
- solidarity

[STUB - exact quote: "working with Claude more human... having a great time"]

- Akós

Akós - [internal/colleague; no public link - confirm attribution]

Protect the brain and body

- 90-min breaks
- talk to a human
- four best hours then stop
- LookAway

Important, but not the full picture

tracing sees outputs; config / training / guardrails stay invisible -> so push

Section 4

The bigger picture

what is this doing to us?

What survives

- taste
- judgement
- the contrarian calls from real expertise

The bottleneck was never the code

scarce -> valuable

STUB - YOUR WORDS

Remember the slot machine?

TBD (your wording)

Hands in the fabric of the universe

Metropolis + Ghost in the Shell stills

Metropolis (1927, dir. Fritz Lang) - Ghost in the Shell (1995, dir. Mamoru Oshii) - cite film + year + director (no single URL)

The real invitation

micro ↔ macro

The humans are still in the loop. We're just tired.

More Star Trek, less Black Mirror.

Thanks

Laura Summers - Lead Design Engineer @ Pydantic